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Why Enrolments in Govt Schools are Falling

A shrinking school-age population, preference for private schools and better child tracking systems have led to falling enrolment numbers



BY SAFEENA HUSAIN

India's government schools have seen enrolment declines for three consecutive years, slipping from 251.8 million in 2022–23 to 248 million in 2023–24, and further down to 246.9 million in 2024–25. But before drawing hasty conclusions about the state of public education, it is essential to understand why this shift is happening.

The primary reason is India's changing demographic landscape. The country's fertility rate has fallen below replacement level, resulting in a shrinking school-age population. This is a fundamental change in India's population structure, moving the country away from its historically young demographic profile toward a more mature one.

Additionally, a significant redistribution of students is occurring. Families are increasingly choosing private schools over government institutions, driven by perceptions of superior learning outcomes, enhanced English language proficiency, and better opportunities for their children. This trend is evident even in rural areas, despite limited financial resources.

A troubling pattern is also visible in how families allocate their limited educational resources. When faced with choosing between government and private schools, parents frequently choose the latter for boys and the former for girls. This is leading to an increasingly feminised government school system, with significant implications for gender equity in educational outcomes.

Some portion of the enrolment decline, though, can be attributed to improved child tracking mechanisms and data collection systems. Better monitoring has reduced duplicate entries and eliminated 'ghost' enrolments that previously inflated official statistics. Though this is encouraging in terms of accurate administrative processes, it means that figures may turn out to be more sobering than earlier expected.



Illustration by RAJ VERMA

EFFORTS TO STOP THIS DECLINE MUST FOCUS ON THE GIRL CHILD, TRANSPORT NEEDS AND LINKING SOCIAL SECURITY NETS TO SCHOOLS

Efforts to address the enrolment decline should be systemic and comprehensive. Firstly, it is important that school mergers and consolidation do not increase the number of out-of-school children. The poorest and most marginalised children are at greatest risk when schools become less accessible due to consolidation. Distance becomes a critical factor, particularly for girls whose families may be less willing to allow them to travel far for education. Any consolidation strategy must account for transportation needs and ensure that school accessibility is maintained for all children, regardless of gender or economic status.

There is also a need for government schools to counter the perception that private education is superior. This requires demonstrating tangible value beyond traditional academic metrics. Enhanced integration with social protection schemes presents a promising avenue for rebuilding this trust. During the pandemic, government schools successfully adapted by providing food rations to replace midday meals, demonstrating their role as comprehensive support systems for vulnerable families. Private schools cannot match such value propositions. Safety nets like direct benefit transfers have also transformed government schools into holistic development platforms rather than merely academic institutions.

The concentration of girls in government schools, too, represents an unprecedented opportunity for targeted investment with potentially transformative returns. Evidence demonstrates that educating girls generates multiplier effects across nine of the 17 Sustainable Development Goals and could contribute approximately 10 per cent to national GDP growth.

Declining enrolment in government schools thus presents a paradox: while concerning from an access perspective, it creates conditions for a more focused, intensive investment in institutions serving the most vulnerable populations. Success in transforming these schools into exemplars of quality and equity could fundamentally alter public perceptions while delivering substantial returns to both individuals and society. ■

The author is the founder of Educate Girls, the NGO which won the Ramon Magsaysay award in 2025